La Source

Contents

Prank 2
Omnipotence Paradox 5
"Spring Elfin" 7
Flood Season 9
Brainstorm in the Suitcase 12
Coins, Balloons, and Ribbons 14

Prank

WPK-01

Only Water Springs Know

Mischief

Life inside the suitcase is tranquil and harmonious.

Most of the time.

Somewhere in the Suitcase

It's a beautiful day, and the sun is shining off the surface of the lake, making it sparkle.

It's an ideal day for boating, reading, napping, and causing mischief.

Charlie: Ahhh!

Charlie: My script, it's drenched.

Charlie: Another metallic hued "raindrop" splashes near the ladies' feet.

Sotheby: My, what a big splash!

Sotheby: Is there an Ogopogo living here?! But Vertin certainly never introduced us to it.

Sotheby: Perhaps it's weeping out of mere shyness, like Mr. Wet Eyes.

Charlie: O-Ogopogo? Isn't that some kind of fiend from those old legends?

Charlie: Let's not speculate, Ms. Sotheby. It's probably just a large fish that happens to be fond of spraying water. Let's continue discussing the script!

plop

The droplets continue to fall, creating sharp and distinct sounds.

Sotheby: But we're not even close to the lake!

Charlie: Oh, you're right. What's this on the ground, then a coin?

Charlie raises her head.

What meets her gaze is neither an Ogopogo nor some water-spraying fish.

Sotheby: **Coins!**

Sotheby: Good heavens, there are so many coins here—almost as many as there are in Father's 385th vault!

Charlie: Now you're just exaggerating. There aren't that many coins. Only enough to buy a small piece of farmland.

Sotheby: Oh, farmland, eh? Could I use it to grow creeping dog grass?

Charlie: ...

The ladies' curious chatter continues, their topics meandering like a river.

They seem to have entirely forgotten about the initial coins that caused the splashes.

La Source: ...

La Source: So boring. I'm almost out of coins.

La Source: When will they finally notice me?!

La Source: She frowns and gives her clay pot a good thump.

La Source: Alright, maybe this place isn't so bad.

La Source: No boring explorers, no pesky, noisy fools making wishes ...

La Source: No more people believing all fountains grant wishes. No more listening to the mumbling of odd phrases every day as people try to toss coins into my pot.

La Source: I'm free! Now I can play tricks on whoever I want!

La Source: ...

La Source: But ...

The ladies nearby remain oblivious to La Source's murmuring, returning to their discussion on the script.

They don't seem bothered at all by a few mere splashes.

La Source's pot lies on the grass nearby, a gentle trickle of water flowing quietly from it.

La Source: Hmph! What a pair of bores!

La Source: ...!

Only few in this world can truly entertain La Source, but thankfully, Vertin has all kinds of strange friends.

Balloon Party: Grass, cupcakes, and balloons—yes, more balloons! That'll make a perfect party!

Baby Blue: Hmm, this blanket here looks just right for a nap.

Baby Blue yawns and settles down in the lushest part of the grass.

ONiON: Careful of the brambles, Ms. Baby Blue!

ONiON: I sincerely suggest you spare the time to watch my new TV series, Wilderness Survival. I'm not saying this for my ratings.

Their discussion falls clearly into La Source's ears.

La Source: Hehe, fresh meat for my next big prank.

La Source: What to do? Fling coins at them? Create an air geyser? Or maybe just dunk water on their heads?

La Source: No, no, no, that's all been done before! Where's the creativity?!

La Source: And if they can't figure out who's pulling the pranks, then, then ...

She glances at the solitary, overturned pot.

She catches a spark of inspiration.

La Source: I know! I can't always hide in the shadows, so I should let them know who's pranking them!

La Source: Ahem. Such is the conduct befitting a well-bred "Spring Elfin."

La Source moves stealthily toward her targets.

She approaches step by step, until even the faintest gasps can be heard.

ONiON: So Wonderland isn't just some make-believe world from a children's book—it's real! The people need to know about this.

ONiON: I appreciate your candor, Baby Blue! This is all very valuable stuff!

ONiON, engrossed in her note-taking, remains oblivious to the approaching prankster.

La Source: Hello there!

The group turns around.

Baby Blue & Balloon Party: ...?

La Source: ...

The two across from her move closer, curiosity on their faces. La Source's legs tremble slightly as she steps back.

La Source: Great, I've scared them!

La Source: But, what next?

La Source: Oh, that's it! I'll pull a prank that'll leave them all stunned!

La Source: I-I'm the Spring Elfin, La Source! Got any wishes you want to come true?

She stands with her hands on her hips and her head held high.

Balloon Party: ...

Baby Blue: Uh?

La Source: What am I talking about? I hate granting wishes!

La Source: Oh! But if they make a wish first, then I'll have a reason to prank them, just like all those other unlucky wish-makers!

La Source: Alright, that's the plan! That's what I'll do!

La Source: Hehe! Yes! Tell me your wishes!

La Source: And you better be excited. You're about to be part of the greatest prank ever! Hehe!

Baby Blue: Hello there. Come. Sit on this blanket. You can take the middle; there's a comfy pillow for you.

She leads La Source by the hand, guiding her to a leafy branch.

La Source: ...!

La Source: This unexpected warmth catches the prankster off guard. She involuntarily clenches her toes.

Balloon Party: Hey, new kid—are you here for the party? How about a balloon?

La Source: Huh? I was going to ask if you had any wishes.

Balloon Party: Here, have a balloon. We have lots and lots of them.

Balloon Party: Hold onto it tight, and don't let it pop, or the insides will—bang! Fly out everywhere.

Balloon Party: Just like that thing over there!

Balloon Party: Balloon Party points to the lonely pot in the grass.

Baby Blue: In Wonderland, we have golden fountains of honey and syrup. This pot seems different, though. Perhaps it's filled with cream and shaved ice.

Baby Blue: Mmm. Let's try it!

She moves lightly toward the pot, the reporter's words following closely behind.

ONiON: Maybe we should do a deep dive interview about this. By the way, Ms. Baby Blue, you didn't mention this in your previous interviews. Please tell us more abou—

La Source: No! That's MY pot!

La Source runs over, sweeps the pot into her arms, and clings to it tightly.

Balloon Party watches on with excitement.

Balloon Party: Oh, a pot! Perfect for keeping balloons in! We should get little pots to give to everyone —ones that are colorful, can change size, and go bubble-bubble-bubble!

This conversation is too bizarre for La Source to handle.

La Source: I-I ...

La Source: I need to go change the water in the pot! Be right back!

Balloon Party: Oh, okay. That's too bad.

Balloon Party: See you soon, friend!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Omnipotence Paradox

WPK-02

Omnipotence Paradox

Bare feet scamper across the lake, across the wilderness, and finally come to rest in a more peaceful place.

Balloons, brambles, blankets—they all vanish from sight, and a proud little chest rises once again.

Corridor, Suitcase

La Source: Phew, finally got away.

La Source: What were they even talking about? I couldn't make head nor tail of it. I thought I was supposed to be the one pranking them, not the other way around!

La Source racks her brain, looking for a logical explanation.

La Source: I know! They're just too young!

La Source: Ah yes, kids' talk is always puzzling, but that's just how it is.

La Source: But a Spring Elfin's pranks should have a higher goal!

She shakes off the confusion and looks around with fresh interest.

The corridor is full of life. Spirits drift here and there, lilies bounce, poets scurry away, and birds dart through the air.

Clearly, these are not the targets for a good prank.

John Titor: ...

La Source: ...!

A passing girl catches her attention.

La Source: Who's that?

La Source: She looks pretty normal. No weird critters or birds tagging along, either. She's just holding a regular old box!

La Source: Hehe, now that's someone ripe for a prank!

She clenches her fists, ready to go.

La Source: Alright, La Source. Now's the time to pull a prank that'll amaze everyone!

John Titor is still lost in thought, oblivious to the "honor" that she has just been graced with.

A mist grows, and the enigmatic Spring Elfin appears in the haze.

La Source: Hello there, lucky lady!

La Source: The magnificent Spring Elfin will now fulfill your wish! Embrace your fate with due gratitude! Tell me—

John Titor: 486F776D616E79776973686573

Her opening speech is cut short.

La Source: Sorry, what?

John Titor: 416E79636F6E646974696F6E73

This isn't quite the reaction she was hoping for.

La Source: You're not even a little excited? This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity!

John Titor: 576865726569737 96F75726C6F676963

La Source: ... Uh ... I ... you ...

La Source: Anybody help?

The mist quickly fades. Yet another blow for La Source.

Fortunately, within the suitcase, there is always someone willing to help, be they human or machine.

Ms. Radio: Are you alright, Ms. La Source? Ms. Titor is asking how many wishes you'll grant and if there are any conditions on them.

La Source: A ... radio?!

John Titor: 4869

Ms. Radio: Pardon my interruption, Ms. Titor, Ms. La Source. I was choosing which music to play today, and I couldn't help but overhear your conversation.

Ms. Radio: It's so nice to hear machine language. It makes me feel at home. Thank you, Ms. John Titor.

Ms. Radio bends her antenna in John Titor's direction.

La Source: Machine ... language?

She has no idea what they're talking about.

Ms. Radio: Don't worry, Ms. La Source, I can translate for you. It's my job to create connections between our friends in the suitcase, after all.

Ms. Radio: Ms. Titor is curious about how many wishes you'll grant for her and what the conditions might be.

La Source: ...

La Source sighs in relief. Things are getting back on track. She can still pull off the prank.

La Source: Hmph, talk about greedy!

La Source: Regardless, the great Spring Elfin will answer you. I shall grant you three wishes, with no conditions!

John Titor: ...

John Titor nods, moving closer to Ms. Radio's dials.

She whispers a series of numbers, and Ms. Radio's antenna flashes in response.

Ms. Radio: Got it. Ms. Titor's first wish is ...

Ms. Radio: For you to do the opposite of her second wish.

La Source: Huh?

Ms. Radio: Her second wish is for you to not grant the third wish.

La Source: What ...?

Ms. Radio: Her third wish is to ignore her first wish.

La Source: Do the opposite of the second ... don't do the third ... ignore the first ...

Steam starts to rise from La Source's head.

La Source: What kind of messed-up wishes are these? They're all impossible to fulfill, aren't they?

La Source: I ... I, I ...

La Source: No! Then, my prank—my wish—won't come true!!!

John Titor smiles.

John Titor: 4F66636F757273656E6F74

John Titor: 596F756172656E6F7461776973686 96E67656C66

La Source: Hold on! What are you saying?!

John Titor walks away, leaving La Source's confusion far behind.

La Source: Hey, Ms. Radio. What's she trying to say?

Ms. Radio: ...

Her role as a translator and her duty to uphold friendships collide.

La Source: ...

The mist surrounding La Source grows denser as tears well in her eyes.

Ms. Radio: Oh, please don't cry, Ms. La Source. It's not good for either of us.

Ms. Radio: I'm more than willing to translate for you.

The mist stabilizes.

Ms. Radio: "Ms. La Source, you're not a wish-granting elfin. Of course, you can't grant wishes."

La Source: Wh-What?!

The mist grows warm, as if the hall has become a hot spring.

La Source: **That's not fair!**

La Source: How could I not be able to grant wishes?!

La Source: I CAN grant them! I just don't WANT to! Why should everyone keep getting something for nothing?!

La Source: I'll show them what a Spring Elfin is really capable of!

TO BE CONTINUED...

"Spring Elfin"

WPK-03

"Spring Elfin"

Bunny Bunny sits tensely in her chair. The smell of the food on her plate has hooked her senses.

Bunny Bunny: No—Mamma don't like chubby girls. Gotta control myself.

Bunny Bunny: But seriously, how cruel do you have to be to show me this flyer?

Bunny Bunny: "Free all-you-can-eat honey and chocolate parfait all day at the Club—starting now!"

She lets out a groan as she balls up the flyer and throws it.

It flies through the air, passing lamps and window sills ...

Before landing perfectly inside a small clay pot.

gurgle

???: ...

The pot starts to overflow with water.

A small head peeks out from the mist.

La Source: Achoo!!!

La Source: Who's making wishes on the sly again?

La Source: Seething with anger, her head wobbles unhappily.

Bunny Bunny: Whoa! Ms. La Source? What are you squatting down there for?

Her softness of tone eases La Source's anger.

La Source: Oh, don't worry. I'm not angry!

She raises her eyebrow, struck by a more pressing thought.

La Source: Ahem. You look troubled—you must have something on your mind!

Bunny Bunny: Me?

Bunny Bunny hesitantly touches her belly.

Bunny Bunny: Is it that obvious?

Having gained the upper hand for the first time in a while, La Source clenches her fist, clearly determined to take this chance to prove herself.

La Source: Perhaps you've got a lot of worries—or problems you can't solve?

La Source: Well, I, the Spring Elfin of boundless generosity, am more than willing to help you out!

Bunny Bunny: Really? You're here to help little ol' me? Could you turn this food into something else once it's in my belly?

Bunny Bunny: Maybe something low-calorie so I don't end up getting fat?

La Source: Hmph, this wish is a piece of cake compared to that number lady's!

La Source sticks her hand into the water pot and retrieves the soggy flyer.

Golden droplets fall from the flyer, coalescing into a familiar shape ...

A cup of golden spring water.

La Source: ...

La Source: Drink this "Super Slim Spring Water," and everything you eat will turn into delicious, low-calorie spring water!

La Source does her best to keep the poise and beauty befitting a wish-granting elfin.

La Source: All done! Now you can eat all the parfait you want!

Bunny Bunny: R-Really?

Bunny Bunny wolfs it down without a second thought.

Bunny Bunny: Thanks a bunch, darling—you're my little angel!

She jumps for joy and hugs La Source. The child is obviously enjoying this special moment.

La Source: Heh-heh.

More and more Bunny girls come to La Source for "Super Slim Spring Water."

Success! La Source has won her admiration, praise, and support.

It's a win-win. The Bunny girls' wishes to keep slim are fulfilled, and so is La Source's wish to fulfill people's wishes.

Everybody's happy!

Well, except the washroom sink at The Bunny. The girls' hands will be all clean after rummaging for their own calorie-crushing spring water in La Source's pot.

La Source: Sometimes it feels pretty good to be a Spring Elfin!

La Source: Yes! I'll be the most successful wish-granting elfin of all time!

She remembers the number lady who mocked her.

La Source: She'll definitely come crawling back, looking all sorry and begging to apologize!

"John Titor": Oh, Ms. La Source! I'm so, so terribly sorry for my detestable behavior!

La Source: Hmph, now you understand the true power of the Spring Elfin!

"John Titor": Please forgive my stupidity and ignorance! La Source, greatest of them all! Let me be your friend! Please!

"John Titor": No, wait. I'll tell my friends about you and make them your loyal fans! Then you'll get even more friends!

La Source: Hmmmmm. I suppose I'll think about it.

La Source: Hehe!

La Source chuckles to herself in glee.

Charlie has stumbled upon this entire exchange, waiting patiently to speak to La Source.

Charlie: Sorry, it seems I've come at a bad time.

Charlie: I'm just here to make a wish. You see, I've got a whole troupe to manage, and, well, some fields back in the countryside ...

Charlie: Just, please help me!

La Source: Hehehe!

Charlie can't quite believe her eyes.

In all her years of show rehearsals, she's never seen someone do a field-sowing dance in a hallway.

She's taken aback by La Source's fervor.

Charlie: Sorry, I'll leave you be!

La Source: Ahem! Make your wish!

La Source: I, the greatest wish-granting elfin, am listening!

Charlie: My wish is ...

TO BE CONTINUED...

Flood Season

WPK-04

Flood Season

The room in the suitcase is set up almost exactly like the real thing.

It accommodates every guest, capturing their curiosity and imagination.

Sotheby: An Ogopogo, with its odd-sounding cry, a gentle shower of coins, and lots of fun friends!

Sotheby: I wonder what interesting things Ms. Sotheby will find today!

Sotheby smooths her skirt, ensuring she looks like a proper lady.

Sotheby: Oh, I almost forgot ...

Sotheby: I made plans with Ms. Charlie to perform a play about a hero outsmarting a dragon! I hope she's assembled a suitable cast!

Sotheby: Otherwise, I'll have to write to Father, asking Mr. Culebre to come here and serve as a stand-in.

She mutters softly as she adjusts her bow once more.

The little lady excitedly pushes open the door, not noticing the surging sound of water outside.

As the door swings open, she is faced with a tidal wave, shimmering with gold.

It's washing over the land and coming right toward her.

Sotheby: Eek! What's going on?!

Sotheby: Is there really an Ogopogo living here? Is it planning to turn this place into its lair or something?

The wave reaches Sotheby, rushing past her legs and soaking the lower half of her skirt.

Of course, this cannot do for a young lady.

And she isn't the only victim.

Sotheby: Um, hello, Mr. Fog.

Oliver Fog: Oliver Fog stands soaking wet in the corridor. He looks quite miserable.

Sotheby glances at his pocket watch.

Sotheby: Isn't it time you clocked out? How come you're still here?

Oliver Fog: Well, I think I made a wrong wish.

He lets out a sigh as he shakes the water off his coat.

Oliver Fog: I wished for Ms. La Source to end work on time today.

Oliver Fog: So she flooded the whole suitcase courtyard. Now everyone has to stop working.

Before Sotheby can respond, distant shouts of surprise catch her attention.

???: Whoa!

Sotheby stands on her toes to get a better view, as a flustered figure sprints toward them at a speed that could give a Teakettler a run for its money.

Sotheby: Oh! Ms. Charlie, you're ever so fast on your feet!

Sotheby: Are you rehearsing for this afternoon's play?

Sotheby watches on with admiration. Charlie has never moved so swiftly, not even when she accidentally let loose those three hundred dwarf mice.

Charlie: ...

Charlie comes to a halt before them, panting heavily.

Charlie: I ... I'm sorry ... I think I've made a blunder ... *sniffle* ...

Sotheby: Huh?

Charlie: I wished for Ms. La Source to find us an actor to play the dragon.

Charlie: She eagerly asked about the requirements for the role, from physique to preferred method of attack.

Sotheby: Oh, that's great!

Charlie: No ... Ms. Sotheby ...

She lowers her head in shame, then continues.

Charlie: She created a real dragon from her spring water!

"Dragon": *roar*

The "dragon" flies over them, leaving a misty haze behind. The three quickly duck their heads.

The flow of ill-conceived wishes seems to have no end.

???: ... Help ... me ...

Sotheby follows the sound, spotting a familiar figure sprawled on the grass.

Sotheby: Oh, Ms. Bunny Bunny, are you okay? You look starved.

Oliver Fog: I understand your situation, Ms. Bunny Bunny. But I must warn you, this grass isn't safe to eat.

Sotheby: Hold on, I have a Full Belly Potion here somewhere. You'll be fine in no time, I assure you!

Bunny Bunny: A potion?! No thanks. I've had enough liquids for a lifetime!

Bunny Bunny: Everything I eat turns into spring water. I ain't had a bite in two days.

Bunny Bunny stares, dumbfounded, as Sotheby proceeds to pull potion after potion from her person.

Sotheby: Oh, that's simply terrible ...

Oliver Fog straightens his hat.

Oliver Fog: No need to worry, folks. At the rate the tide is rising, we'll all be underwater soon. Then we'll have much bigger problems to deal with.

He snaps shut his pocket watch, ready for what's to come.

Oliver Fog: Right now, the most important thing is to find La Source.

The group hurries through the Wilderness.

Charlie: I ... I think I've spotted her ...

Sotheby: My goodness—there she is! How is she balancing up there?

La Source: If a LITTLE spring water doesn't solve the problem, then how about a LOT of spring water?!

La Source: Now that I've fulfilled all their wishes, they're sure to admire and respect me! I'll have loads of friends!

La Source: Hehe! I never knew granting wishes could be so much fun!

La Source: It's even better than pulling pranks!

La Source: No wonder everyone loves wish-granting elfins!

La Source: From now on, I'll be known as the Wish-Granting Elfin La Source!

She relaxes joyfully on the wave, the water droplets splashing her skirt.

Over on what can only be called the "shore" come the calls of the others.

La Source: Hm? What's that?

La Source leans over the crest of the wave and spots two tiny figures in the distance.

Sotheby: ...!

La Source: Are they trying to thank me?

La Source: But I need to make sure I focus on helping new people. If I spend all my time acknowledging thanks, I won't be able to fulfill everyone's wishes.

La Source: Farewell, my enthusiastic friends!

She bows.

Then she turns and confidently strides away.

La Source: Whoa!

Blind confidence can have its problems, especially when you're walking on moving water.

???: Are you okay?

The Spring Elfin raises her head. A familiar figure stands in front of her.

???: You've got a great party going. Let's work together to make it even better!

La Source: And you are ...?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Brainstorm in the Suitcase

WPK-05

Brainstorm in the Suitcase

People from all corners of the suitcase have gathered together in serious discussion.

X: I believe you are all aware of our current predicament.

X: I regret to inform you: our lives in the suitcase have reached a critical moment!

X: As long as the flood remains, none of us will be able to get on with our work.

Oliver Fog offers a well-timed clap.

Mesmer Jr.: A pointless conclusion.

Mesmer Jr.: Not to point the finger at anyone in particular, but with so many arcanists here ...

Mesmer Jr.: Isn't there anyone who can use their arcane skill to stop the flood?

X shrugs helplessly.

X: If this incident were created by an arcane skill alone, then it's possible it could be dispelled.

X: However, the problem caused by Ms. La Source is an abundance of ordinary spring water.

X: What we're experiencing is a flood in the physical sense.

Oliver Fog: Very well. I suggest we promptly come up with emergency aid legislation and a plan for work suspension.

Oliver adjusts his hat, looking grimly at the rising tide.

X: Of course, if there's anyone kind enough to help me set up the machinery ...

X: I may be able to engineer a multipurpose drainage system, and we can avert this whole crisis before Ms. Vertin returns.

Oliver Fog: Alright, I can take on work assignments during office hours—at least until the work suspension plan is in place.

X: Thank you for your diligence, Mr. Fog.

One after another, the members of the group join in.

Sotheby: Ms. Sotheby is ready to lend a hand! But how will we deal with the "dragon"? It's still roaming around the Wilderness!

Sotheby: And poor Ms. Bunny Bunny is so hungry that stars are bursting from her eyes!

Charlie: You mean she's "seeing stars," Ms. Sotheby.

Clearly, one plan cannot solve all of these issues.

The friends look at each other, at a loss.

Oliver Fog: This is just like the Great Smog of London. Protesting against the factories won't stop the pollution. When one factory closes, another will just take its place.

Oliver Fog: No, we need to understand the true cause. Otherwise, we'll never solve the problem. So ...

Several pairs of eyes converge upon him.

Oliver Fog: We need to draft a formal protest petition to present to Ms. La Source!

All: ...

The group exchanges uncertain looks.

X: Ahem, perhaps we should consider more friendly measures.

Sotheby: But why has Ms. La Source so abruptly changed her demeanor? She's not exactly a havoc-wreaking critter, or, is she?

Sotheby: Could it be that she's the Ogopogo we've been looking for?

X: It is worth considering what caused the sudden change. I don't think we need to worry about any Ogopogos, though.

The issue goes back and forth among the arcanists.

The crowd grows larger.

For a seasoned reporter, this is clearly a prime opportunity for self-promotion.

ONiON: Friends, it's good to see so many of you so concerned by these baffling mystical events.

ONiON: Please stay tuned for our special broadcast.

The imaginary camera starts rolling, and a live show segment officially begins.

ONiON: Ladies and gentlemen, you're watching a special episode of Headonion! What's gotten into the Spring Elfin? Why is the Wilderness flooded? And what's going on with the "dragon" in the lake?

ONiON: Join me as we delve into the Spring Elfin Special!

Sotheby: Wow! I've never seen a real live broadcast before!

She looks around with excitement as she fixes her outfit.

ONiON: Our story starts on a sunny afternoon ...

ONiON: Balloon Party and Baby Blue were taking a lakeside walk while we interviewed them about Wonderland parties.

ONiON: At that time, Ms. La Source was the only one privy to our conversation.

Sotheby: Parties?!

ONiON: Even though Ms. La Source hadn't disclosed her identity, her clay pot had already given her away.

ONiON: And now, a legend about the Fountain of Youth.

ONiON: Let's turn back the clock a few centuries—back to Brittany—back to the lush, legendary forest of Brocéliande ...

ONiON: Legend has it that the great arcanist Merlin met the Lady of the Lake, Viviane, in this very forest.

Sotheby: Ooh, I've heard of this!

She raises her hand enthusiastically, playing the part of the supportive audience member every show should have.

ONiON: In fact, the Fountain of Barenton in Brocéliande is neither a wishing fountain nor a fountain of youth.

ONiON: It's just an ordinary spring. What makes it different from the others is the presence of our very own Ms. La Source.

ONiON: Many were drawn by the legend of instant wealth, only to leave disillusioned.

ONiON: And over time, her gurgling clay pot was left alone in the increasingly desolate forest.

ONiON: After many years, a painter caught sight of the fabled spring nymph amidst the mists.

ONiON: Sadly, even the most beautiful painting couldn't change a thing.

ONiON's tale continues to reach back into the past.

Sotheby listens intently, her spirit gently lifting, leaving behind the waist-deep floodwater, bidding farewell to the "dragon" in the Wilderness, and heading toward a fascinating, uninhabited realm.

Sadly, her body is still firmly planted in the increasingly deepening water.

What's even sadder is that no one else seems to have been affected by the story in any way.

All: ...

Oliver Fog: Allow me to sincerely propose my plan to you all once again—why don't we put it to a vote?

X: Is anyone willing to be a test subject for the X-301 Sponge-Type Decontaminator?

ONiON: Hey—hold up, folks! We're just about to get to the heart of the tale—

The group shakes their heads in resignation.

ONiON: Wow, do people really have such a hard time accepting the truth of the world?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Coins, Balloons, and Ribbons

WPK-06

Coins, Balloons, and Ribbons

ONiON's show isn't quite over yet.

Thankfully, the water level hasn't risen for quite some time.

X: Hold on, everyone! We're almost there!

A small boat bears its passengers gently toward the heart of the lake.

Sotheby: Mr. X, your X-301 seems to be sinking by the second.

X: Don't worry, Ms. Sotheby. This vessel is equipped with special sponges capable of absorbing an unusually high volume of water. By the time we've sunk to the bottom, this thing should've already absorbed at least 85% of the spring water.

X: That'll be enough to ensure we don't drown.

Oliver Fog: ...

Oliver Fog: I hope this doesn't take too long—there's only an hour and fifteen minutes left of the workday.

X: Fingers crossed!

As the boat continues to drift, the vast waves can no longer conceal a certain petite figure.

Two other figures emerge.

The two figures from the start of ONiON's tale.

La Source: ...!

Balloon Party: I kept thinking about the party—thinking and thinking—but I kept thinking that my thinking was wrong. Like something was missing.

Balloon Party: Now I know what it was! We need water! A big water wave for the party! And you're the best water wave maker I've ever seen! The very best!

She takes La Source's hand, earnestly passing her a balloon.

La Source: M-Me? I'm the best?

Balloon Party: Would you like to help us throw a perfect party? I mean, we need more candy and streamers, and balloons, of course!

Balloon Party: Oh, and more waves! Big ones!

Baby Blue: We could make that "dragon" a little smaller so he can wear a garland!

La Source: You ... you'd like me to join you?

Sotheby: Ms. La Source!

The sponge boat has finally reached its destination.

The lake water has already reduced significantly.

A crowd gathers around La Source. For her, this is quite an unusual honor.

La Source: Ah! Are you here to make a wish?

Oliver Fog: Actually, we've come to—

He presents his meticulously drafted letter of protest.

La Source doesn't even glance at it. She just shakes her head solemnly.

La Source: Sorry, I don't have time to help you now!

La Source: I've accepted an invitation from Baby Blue and Balloon Party! We're going to have the most spectacular, grandest party ever—with big water waves, too!

The group looks on in surprise.

La Source: Of course, if you'd like to join ...

She starts to think again.

La Source: Hmm, it's not really asking for something for nothing, so I can agree to that.

X chuckles.

X: So, you're saying that you have to pull all the spring water you used for wishes back into your pot in order to have your party?

La Source: Exactly! You didn't think you'd get something for nothing forever, did you?!

She clings to the pot, eyeing X warily.

Sotheby: Ooh-ooh! I'd like to come, please!

Balloon Party: Certainly, Ms. Sotheby.

They dash off together, four bouncing balloons following in their wake.

Obviously, they have more important things to attend to.

The rest stand there, stunned.

X: Well, I suppose that's that.

Oliver Fog: Looks like I'll be able to clock out on time.

Oliver Fog: But I have to say, we really must set up emergency plans and compensation for work stoppages in case something like this happens again.

He opens his umbrella as he works to clear away the mist. Meanwhile, ONiON starts recording again.

X: It seems you've got yourself some exciting new material, Ms. ONiON. Congratulations.

He nods and makes his way.

ONiON: Absolutely!

ONiON: I'm planning to showcase another fantastic episode with an in-depth interview and analysis of the central figure! Well, the footage is ready. It just needs some final touches.

ONiON: This'll be one for the ages!

She excitedly fiddles with the camera equipment beside her, oblivious to the fact that X is long gone.

The old video player rewinds slowly.

click

ONiON: Ladies and gentlemen. Brace yourselves, for you are about to witness—

ONiON: The "Getting to Know You" episode of our Spring Elfin Special!

ONiON: This segment's material was captured purely by accident. Nevertheless, I've decided to use it to conclude our story.

ONiON: But trust me, this wasn't just a spur-of-the-moment decision—oop!

ONiON: Shh, let's keep our voices down.

Not far from the lakeside, Balloon Party, Baby Blue, and ONiON sit on the ground.

The camera, its red light flashing, tilts toward the grass, revealing a figure hidden within.

The child clutching the pot is repeating the same gesture.

La Source: I-I am the Spring Elfin, La Source!

La Source: Delighted to m-meet you!

La Source: Trust me, I can fulfill your wishes! Lots and lots of wishes!

La Source: If you're willing to be friends with me.

click

The last of the mist is drawn into Oliver Fog's umbrella, and he closes it up with a flourish.

A renewed calm is brought to the suitcase.

Oliver Fog: *sigh* An elfin's mood is more unpredictable than the policies of the London authorities.

Oliver Fog: And wasn't I just as naive as any common voter when I made my wish to her?

Oliver Fog: I suppose, in the end, we can only depend on ourselves and the friends we hold dear.

He shakes his head in resignation.

ONiON: Ah, Mr. Fog, I'm glad you're still here. I'm cooking up a new exclusive interview, and I'd love to have you take part!

Oliver Fog: I'm off duty.

And just like that, the flood is dealt with.

John Titor: ...

John Titor has yet to grasp the trouble that her wish put everyone through.

She simply puts on her earmuffs and retreats into a world of hexadecimal codes.

Perhaps it's best she stays this way—at least until the greatest party ever conceived has been put on.

THE END